A raucous democracy soon to be the world's most populous country is never short of either news or personalities. A combination of politicians, sportspersons, movie stars and businesspersons and roller coaster-like events make the expression 'may you live in interesting times' seem like it was coined for India. This makes it so difficult for us here at INDIA TODAY to choose our Newsmaker of the Year—a person or phenomenon that shaped the year's significant events. The past two years, in particular, have certainly been not only interesting but unprecedented in this century. Our Newsmaker in 2020 was the Coronavirus—a microscopic creature that brought the world to a screeching halt, causing the most significant disruption since the Second World War.

The second wave of the Covid-19 pandemic this year caused mayhem, killing over 200,000 Indians, prompting the Washington-based Center for Global Development to describe it as 'the worst tragedy since Partition'. There were other significant events and newsmakers, of course. Prime Minister Narendra Modi took on the mantle of a reformer to convince the nation that self-reliance and privatisation were not necessarily antithetical. A farmer leader's tears became a rallying point for an agitation that ended only after the Union government had withdrawn three contentious farm laws. A bizarre plot saw crooked police officers planting an explosives-laden SUV near the home of India's wealthiest individual. The fallout saw a Mumbai police commissioner on the run from his colleagues. A superstar's son was arrested in a drug bust. A chief minister halted what seemed like an unstoppable BJP juggernaut in her home state. Two new chief ministers rose to prominence in Assam and Tamil Nadu. A gifted athlete brought India its first-ever Olympic gold in track and field. In business, unicorns unleashed the animal spirits of young Indian entrepreneurs. A new generation of stars became household names as Over The Top (OTT) series held homebound Indians in thrall. An Indian YouTuber who lost his parents to Covid crossed 20 million subscribers.



January 11, 2021

Yet, in the midst of all of this was a reminder that our biggest battle—against Covid-19—is still on. More than a quarter of a billion infections have been reported worldwide, killing over 5.3 million people over the past two years. The pandemic shows no signs of abating. Newer variants of the virus continue to stalk the globe spreading death and fear. The silver lining to this health crisis—a very significant one—is that India is the world's largest producer of vaccines. Early this year, they were made available in India to battle the coronavirus. This meant that instead of being out with a begging bowl at the mercy of the world for billions of doses, we were—for a change—self-sufficient.

The Pune-based Serum Institute of India, headed by Adar Poonawalla, produces over 1.5 billion vaccine shots a year, and 88 per cent of the 1.4 billion vaccine doses administered in India till date were of Covishield, produced by the Serum Institute from the Oxford-AstraZeneca formula. Meanwhile, Krishna Ella of Bharat Biotech was able to field an indigenously developed vaccine, Covaxin, almost as quickly as the world's pharma majors. These two vaccines blunted the sharp edge of the pandemic in India. Without them, we would have had hundreds of thousands of seriously ill patients crowding hospitals and many more deaths. The safety net provided by the vaccines and also a commendable nationwide government effort to administer over a billion doses in just 10 months averted a calamity. The fact that fewer people were falling sick gave the economy time and space to recover. Vaccines thus made the difference between chaos and catastrophe for India this year.

This is why we chose Ella and Poonawalla as our Newsmakers of the Year. They've been bold and innovative in attaching their careers and reputations to producing these vaccines knowing that lives were at stake—if anything had gone wrong or if the vaccines were ineffective, it would have meant disaster for them and the country. Ella says he wanted to demonstrate that India was up there with the rest of the world in cutting-edge vaccine research. For Poonawalla, making an alliance with AstraZeneca and expanding his vaccine production line exponentially was a high-risk venture that finally paid off.

This year, we've modified our format. In addition to the major Newsmaker, we decided that there were many other newsmakers of the year who need to be recognised. So, we created nine categories—politics, public life, business, activism, controversy, professionals, sports, entertainment and the arts—with a newsmaker in each. They feature personalities who made the news in their respective domains. Hopefully, the coronavirus will become a distant memory in the year ahead and we can look forward to a robust economic revival. ■



(Aroon Purie)